

Federal Judge Temporarily Blocks Border Wall Work in Texas' Big Bend

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A federal court in Texas on Friday temporarily blocked the Trump administration from building a border wall and other **infrastructure** across the state's Big Bend region. The ruling pauses construction while the court considers a legal challenge; it does not settle the case.

The order includes Big Bend National Park, which sits on a bend of the Rio Grande River. It also covers the entire Big Bend border sector, roughly 500 miles long. That is about a quarter of the roughly 2,000-mile southern border with Mexico.

The projects are part of a \$46 billion administration effort that includes 30-foot-tall steel walls, vehicle barriers, roads and surveillance technology. Landowners, businesses and environmentalists in the region have united in opposition.

Opponents argue that the area's remote location and rugged landscape already discourage illegal border crossings. They also say the administration violated the law by issuing **waivers** to bypass **regulations**. A waiver allows an exception to a rule. The lawsuit challenges bypassing rules intended to protect the environment, culture and **archaeology**. It was brought by an environmental organization, advocates for a historic church in Ruidosa and a river guide.

Judge Kathleen Cardone said the **plaintiffs**, the people bringing the lawsuit, were likely to succeed on at least one claim. She also found that they were likely to suffer serious harm that could not be undone without an **injunction**, a court order that stops an action. She said the public interest favored granting the order. Customs and Border Protection and the Department of Homeland Security did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The first wall panels went up in the sector in mid-September. Bulldozers clearing land in the national park in August prompted opposition from both Republicans and Democrats. Customs and Border Protection paused activity there, but that pause expired on September 30. The administration says it is reevaluating plans for the park and has not announced its decision.

Park advocates welcomed the ruling. Tiernan Sittenfeld, president and CEO of the National Parks Conservation Association, called for the administration to repair damage, meet with border communities and find other solutions.

Word Treasure

infrastructure -- Structures and systems, such as roads and barriers.

waivers -- Permissions to make exceptions to rules.

regulations -- Official rules.

archaeology -- The study of past human life through objects and places people left behind.

plaintiffs -- The people or groups bringing a lawsuit.

injunction -- A court order that requires an action or stops one.

Background you need

A waiver allows an exception to a rule.

Plaintiffs are the people or groups bringing a lawsuit.

A temporary injunction can stop an action while a court considers a case.

Break it down

Introduces the temporary ruling and explains that the case remains unsettled.

Describes the border sector and the administration's construction plan.

Explains opponents' arguments, the lawsuit and the judge's findings.

Reviews construction and the earlier park pause.

Closes with the administration's review and Sittenfeld's proposed next steps.

Why it matters

The case concerns how government construction plans interact with environmental and cultural protection rules. The temporary order affects Big Bend National Park and the wider border sector.

Test what you remember

1. What is the status of the legal case after the ruling?
 - (A) The court has dismissed every claim
 - (B) The plaintiffs have ended their lawsuit
 - (C) The government has withdrawn its plans
 - (D) The court is still considering it
2. About how much of the southern border does the Big Bend sector cover?
 - (A) About a quarter of the border
 - (B) About three quarters of the border
 - (C) About half of the border
 - (D) About a tenth of the border
3. Which groups brought the lawsuit described in the article?
 - (A) A tourism group, wall builders and a local teacher
 - (B) An environmental group, church advocates and a river guide
 - (C) A business group, road builders and a park guide
 - (D) A school group, church leaders and a land surveyor
4. What use of waivers do opponents challenge?
 - (A) Reducing the planned height of steel walls
 - (B) Extending the deadline for public comments
 - (C) Changing the location of the federal court
 - (D) Bypassing environmental and cultural protection rules
5. What did Cardone say about the plaintiffs' claims?
 - (A) They had withdrawn their main argument
 - (B) They had already won every claim
 - (C) They were likely to win at least one
 - (D) They needed to file a new lawsuit
6. What did Tiernan Sittenfeld call for?
 - (A) Damage repairs and discussions with border communities
 - (B) Faster construction and fewer community meetings
 - (C) New steel panels and wider park roads
 - (D) An end to reviews and expanded surveillance

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: A

1. Judge Kathleen Cardone: She found that the plaintiffs were likely to succeed on at least one claim, could face harm that could not be undone, and had the public interest in their favor.
2. Tiernan Sittenfeld: The National Parks Conservation Association president and CEO called for repairing damage, meeting with border communities and finding other solutions.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):